

MOTHERBOARDS

The last couple of years have seen the release of a multitude of chipsets from Intel, NVIDIA, AMD, and SiS. Each of these have their advantages, so there's a myriad of options to choose from when it comes to motherboards.

NVIDIA 680I/650I CHIPSET BOARDS

The Reigning Champion

ASUS Striker Extreme

The NVIDIA 680i has been around for quite some time, and was a path-breaking chipset at its launch. Thanks to the future-proofing by NVIDIA, it's still got the power to take on some of the newer chipsets. The ASUS Striker Extreme, which belongs to the "Republic of Gamers" franchise, is based on the 680i, and has a lot of copper heat-pipes and heatsinks to take care of the cooling needs of the Northbridge and Southbridge. There is support for multiple graphics cards in SLI configuration, and along with support for 8-channel HD Audio, this board is good for gamers.

The Contender

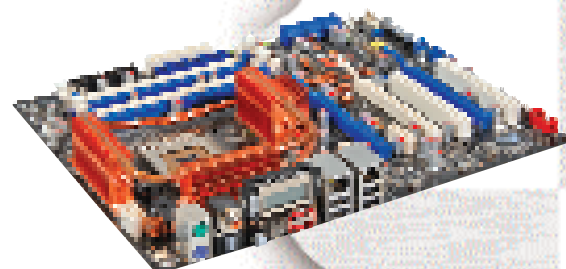
ASUS P5N32-E SLI

This board has one of the best-looking cooling solutions, and the layout is excellent. There are heat-pipes and heatsinks for the Northbridge as well as the Southbridge; this makes it run cooler than other boards in its category. It's actually very similar to the ASUS Striker Extreme in terms of most features and performance, with certain exceptions, notably the absence of solid-state capacitors, which are important for a board's longevity, and a few fancy things like LED buttons right on the board for power On/Off, reset, and CMOS reset.

The Award

ASUS Striker Extreme

The ASUS Striker Extreme posted excellent scores in every benchmark, and top-scored in almost every gaming benchmark. It has a good bundle of games (including GRAW), and accessories such as cooling fans and USB brackets are also provided. Priced somewhat high (Rs 21,400), this is the Zero1 award winner in this category.



INTEL P965 CHIPSET BOARDS

The Reigning Champion

ASUS P5B Premium Vista Edition

The P965 chipset is pretty old, but it's a well-known secret that the chipset unofficially supports the 1333 MHz FSB through BIOS updates, and thus has support for the new Penryn—which breathes new life into this seemingly fading chipset. The ASUS P5B Premium Vista Edition is based on the P965; it is a very feature-rich and fast board, though it costs quite a bit (Rs 14,750). It supports up to seven SATA hard drives and an additional one via the E-SATA port. There is also support for legacy PCI cards (three slots). It has all-solid-state capacitors, which add to its stability and increase its life.

The Contenders

MSI P965 Platinum

A board that's been around for quite some time, the P965 Platinum supports up to six SATA devices and one E-SATA. The BIOS supports overclocking with fine adjustments, making it a good choice for enthusiasts. Being a dated board, it was natural for it to be a bit behind in terms of features as compared to the Reigning Champion, but it is priced well, and performance is superior.

The Award

ASUS P5B Premium Vista Edition

The ASUS P5B Premium Vista Edition is eminently overclockable. Performance across the range of our tests was one of the best in its category. The bundle is handsome: an IR remote receiver (to control several functions, including the ability to hibernate, power down, and even play music), an array microphone, and a tiny LCD screen that allows you to view pop-ups such as RSS feeds (it will even sync with Web sites when your PC is on). You have a clear Zero1 winner in this ageing but not toothless category.



INTEL INTEGRATED SOLUTIONS

The Reigning Champion

Gigabyte GA-G33-DS3R

Integrated graphics platforms are of high importance in India because of cost considerations. The Gigabyte GA-G33-DS3R motherboard, based

on the Intel G33 chipset, has a very good layout, is very well-built, and looks attractive. It employs Realtek's latest ALC889A codec-based HD-compliant sound solution.

The Contender

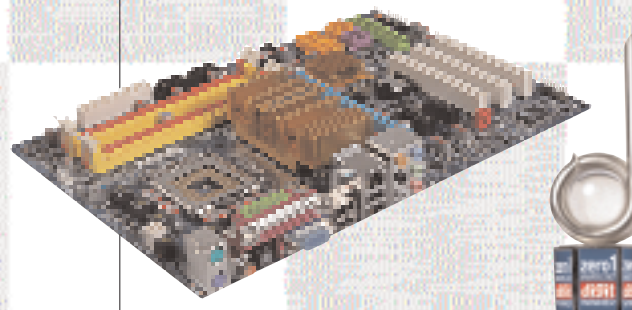
Gigabyte GA-G33M-S2H

The GA-G33M-S2H, though also from Gigabyte, is clearly built for a different target audience. Priced at an unbeatable Rs 5,950, this board has an HDMI port that lets you hook up a compliant display or TV. With the ALC889A-based HD audio solution, this board screams that it is one of the best solutions for an HTPC.

The Award

Gigabyte GA-G33-DS3R

The Gigabyte GA-G33-DS3R is an enthusiast's solution with greater overclockability, solid-state capacitors, and an ATX form factor. In addition to six internal SATA devices, it supports two E-SATA devices too. It supports an FSB of 1333 MHz, thus extending support to the latest Intel processors. If you decide that the integrated graphics is inadequate, you can opt for any PCI-Express graphics card, thanks to the x16 port. (PCI slots also figure.) This motherboard is priced at Rs 9,500 and is worth every penny, which makes it our Zero1 award winner.



AMD INTEGRATED SOLUTIONS

The Reigning Champion

Gigabyte GA-MA69G-S3H

Integrated graphics platforms are of high importance in The AMD platform is still strong, delivering good performance at good value. The Gigabyte GA-MA69G-S3H has a nice layout, which makes installation of add-on cards very easy. There are three PCI slots. It supports the latest AMD processors with the AM2 socket, and an FSB of 1600/2000 MHz. Up to four SATA devices are supported, and there's even an E-SATA bracket.

The Contender

Zebronic ZEB-N61M2

The onboard graphics on this board can handle low to medium gaming, and the 8-channel audio solution is decent, too. This is one of the oldest boards in the category, so it loses out on new features, but it more than made up with good performance and an unmatched price of Rs 2,150.

The Award

Gigabyte GA-MA69G-S3H

The Gigabyte GA-MA69G-S3H delivers solid performance, ahead of much of its competition, especially in benchmarks such as PCMark 2005. The integrated Radeon x1250 delivers decent performance in gaming, and has support for HD video playback, which is well-complemented by the 8-channel HD audio onboard. Add to this the DVI-to-HDMI connector bundled along, and you have a board that makes an excellent choice for an HTPC.



INTEL P35 CHIPSET

The Reigning Champion

ASUS P5K Premium

The P35 is a relatively new chipset from Intel, and supports the newest breed of processor architecture—the 45 nm Penryn. The Asus P5K Premium has an excellent layout and exceptionally good build quality. The use of high-quality components, such as solid-state capacitors, adds to the board's stability and longevity. Good support for overclocking is another feature, and this makes it an enthusiast's delight. It supports up to 8 GB of DDR2 memory at 1066 MHz, more than enough to take care of your needs for years.

The Contender

ASUS P5K3 Deluxe WiFi-AP; Gigabyte GA-P35-DS3R

Both the Asus P5K3 Deluxe WiFi-AP and the Gigabyte GA-P35-DS3R are well-laid-out, high-end motherboards with good build quality. Both support the latest Intel processors and also DDR3 memory at 1333 MHz, meaning they're quite future-proof. While the Gigabyte board supports up to eight SATA devices and one E-SATA, the ASUS has Wi-Fi onboard, along with support for CrossFire. As far as performance goes, these were almost neck-and-neck, and a little behind the Reigning Champion. At the final tally, these stood too close to each other, and it was only fair to award both of them second place in this category.

The Award

ASUS P5K Premium

The ASUS P5K Premium—the Zero1 winner—delivered knockout performances in whatever tests were thrown its way; it was the top scorer in its category. With CrossFire, HD audio, dual Gigabit, and even Wi-Fi onboard, this board is a gamer's delight. Though it is a bit expensive at Rs 15,870, it is well worth the price considering the performance and the features you get.

